



Language

What you say — words, sentences and how ideas flow · 14 cards

FLOW & FLUENCY



Speech flow

Did your words come out smoothly, or did you keep stopping mid-thought?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Fluency* — the rubric scores you from Pre-A1 (long silences, isolated words) all the way to C2 (effortless, deliberate pauses). Smooth flow is the core fluency signal at every level.



False starts

How often did you stop, restart or correct yourself mid-sentence?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Fluency* — visible in A1 (stops between every word) through B1 (planning pauses present but meaning survives) to C1 (only a conceptually difficult subject causes any disruption).



Filler words

Um, uh, like, you know — how many crept in?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Fluency* — fillers appear at A2–B1 as the learner tries to hold their turn. At C1 the rubric notes gaps are overcome through circumlocution, not filler. Fillers are a fluency signal, not a vocabulary one.

GRAMMAR & ACCURACY



Tense accuracy

Did you use the right tense — past for stories, present for opinions?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Grammar* — A2 systematically mixes tenses ('I make one project where the team is build'). B1 achieves mostly correct tense use. C1 uses the full range of complex structures naturally, including conditionals.



Sentence structure

Were your sentences complete and in the right order?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Grammar* — Pre-A1 produces only noun clusters. A1 shows very simple word order. B2 uses some complex sentence forms. C1 uses structures like 'Had I anticipated...' naturally and accurately.

Subject-verb match

Did the verb match the subject — 'he goes', not 'he go'?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Grammar* — A2 forgets to mark agreement frequently but the message stays clear. B1 achieves mostly correct agreement. C1 maintains consistent accuracy throughout.

VOCABULARY & RANGE

Word variety

Did you use different words — or repeat the same ones over and over?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Vocabulary* — A1 repeats the same basic words. B1 shows some variety but repetition appears when vocabulary gaps arise. C1 has a broad repertoire, and the rubric explicitly notes that 'gaps are readily overcome with circumlocutions'.

Technical words

Did you use the right words for your field — naturally, not forced?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Vocabulary* — B1 searches visibly: 'a kind of database tool... like MySQL'. B2 uses domain vocabulary naturally: 'connection pooling to manage database load'. C1 blends technical precision with idiomatic ease.

Vocabulary level

Simple, accessible or sophisticated — where does your language land overall?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Vocabulary* — the rubric tracks this from 'isolated words about personal details only' (A1) through 'sufficient range to give clear descriptions' (B2) to 'broad lexical repertoire' with idiomatic and colloquial language (C1).

Power words

Did you choose strong, active words — or settle for weak and vague ones?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Vocabulary* — C1 explicitly notes: 'formulates thoughts precisely, gives emphasis, eliminates ambiguity, aware of connotative meaning'. Choosing words for impact is a marker of upper-level vocabulary range.

Working around gaps

When you couldn't find the exact word, did you find another way to say it?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Vocabulary* — circumlocution is explicitly named in the rubric at B1 ('lexical gaps cause hesitation and circumlocution') and C1 ('gaps readily overcome with circumlocutions'). This is a scored vocabulary strategy, not a failure.

COHERENCE & IDEAS

Idea connection

Did your ideas link together — or feel like a random list?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Cohesion* — A1 produces a linear list of words. B1 links elements into a sequence with some logical flow. C1 achieves 'clear, smoothly flowing, well-structured speech' with controlled use of cohesive devices.

Connector words

However, therefore, although — did you go beyond 'and' and 'but'?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Cohesion* — A1 uses only 'and' or 'then'. A2 adds 'but' and 'because'. B2 uses 'although', 'as a result', 'despite'. C1 has a 'variety of linking words to mark relationships between ideas clearly'.

CONVERSATION

Back and forth

Could you keep the conversation going without needing a lot of help?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Interaction* — A1 is totally dependent on repetition and rephrasing. B1 manages simple exchanges but loses confidence on unexpected questions. C1 manages conversation naturally and handles challenging follow-ups with ease.

Register

Did you sound professional — not too casual, not robotic?

 **Where it comes from:** *CEFR Interaction* — B2 achieves 'regular interaction without imposing strain'. C1 explicitly adjusts register and 'has a good command of idiomatic expressions and colloquialisms with awareness of connotative levels of meaning'.



Confidence

How you sound — voice, energy and presence signals · 8 cards

VOLUME & PROJECTION



Volume level

Were you loud and clear — or did the listener have to strain to hear you?

Where it comes from: VCP — Volume is one of the four core acoustic signals the rubric measures. VCP 1: consistently below audible threshold, words regularly lost. VCP 4: clear and well-projected throughout, every word received without effort.



Voice consistency

Did your volume hold steady — or drop when the questions got harder?

Where it comes from: VCP — the rubric explicitly scores whether signals 'hold or collapse under pressure'. VCP 2 collapses with no recovery. VCP 3 wobbles but recovers. VCP 4 holds throughout — a 'slight natural drop' is normal but does not persist.

PACE & RHYTHM



Speech speed

100–160 words per minute — not rushing, not dragging.

Where it comes from: VCP — Pace is one of the four core signals. The rubric scores consistency relative to your own baseline. VCP 1: far too fast (words blur) or far too slow (dead spaces). VCP 4: controlled and steady, pace 'belongs to the candidate'.

PAUSES & SILENCE



Pause quality

Did your silences feel calm and deliberate — or lost and panicked?

Where it comes from: VCP — Pause is one of the four core signals. The rubric distinguishes purposeful from disruptive pauses. VCP 1: mid-sentence silences of 2.5+ seconds or one anxious unbroken rush. VCP 4: pauses are 'owned by the candidate — deliberate, not imposed'.



Thinking vs. filler pause

A silent beat before answering = good. Um, uh instead of silence = not.

Where it comes from: VCP — the rubric notes that at VCP 2, filled pauses (um, uh, like) appear frequently, 'breaking the flow and drawing attention away from content'. At VCP 4, every pause reads as intentional — the listener never hears a filler as a loss of control.

TIMING & READINESS



Start time

Did you take 2–4 seconds to think — or rush straight in, or freeze?

Where it comes from: VCP — Latency is one of the four core signals. Good range: 2–5 seconds. VCP 1: under 1 second (panic) or over 6 seconds (overwhelmed). VCP 4: consistent 2–4 seconds — 'the candidate has a process for handling any question and the latency reflects it'.



Pressure hold

Did your voice stay steady when the question got harder?

Where it comes from: VCP — the rubric's key distinction between levels is whether signals hold under pressure. VCP 2: holds on familiar ground only. VCP 3: holds under pressure with wobble but recovery present. VCP 4: signals hold under pressure and recovery from any dip is immediate.

LISTENER IMPRESSION



Listener impression

What would a real interviewer walk away thinking about you?

Where it comes from: VCP — each level ends with a 'listener experience' descriptor. VCP 1: 'a listener would find this candidate very difficult to evaluate'. VCP 2: 'unsure which version of this person would show up on the job'. VCP 3: 'a little nervous but I trust them'. VCP 4: 'this person sounds like they belong in the room'.



Thinking

How you think — structure, depth and quality of your answers · 14 cards

RELEVANCE



On target

Did you answer what was actually asked — not a different question?

Where it comes from: Thinking rubric, Relevance — Score 0: 'response could be an answer to any question'. Score 2: 'directly addresses the question, connects to a real experience'. Score 4: 'goes beyond the question, connects to a broader professional principle'.



No drift

Did you stay on point — or wander into general, unrelated claims?

Where it comes from: Thinking rubric, Relevance — Score 1: 'stays at the level of general intention, does not connect to a real experience'. Score 3: 'deliberately selects or constructs the strongest, most relevant example — no drift'. Score 4: 'sophisticated, memorable, every sentence earns its place'.



Best example

Did you pick the strongest example — not just the first one that came to mind?

Where it comes from: Thinking rubric, Relevance — Score 2: 'uses a real example, possibly the first one that came to mind'. Score 3: 'deliberately selects or constructs the strongest, most relevant example rather than the first one'. Score 4: 'example is 'precise, memorable and directly illuminates the competency'.

SPECIFICITY



Named context

Did you name a real project, place or situation — not just 'once at work'?

Where it comes from: Thinking rubric, Specificity — Score 0: 'no situation named, answer is hollow and unverifiable'. Score 2: 'names a real context, a person or role, a specific task'. Score 3: 'exact steps, amounts, dates, documents, systems — detail precise enough to be recreated'.



Numbers and facts

Did you include real numbers, dates or names — not vague amounts?

 **Where it comes from:** Thinking rubric, Specificity — Score 1: 'no numbers, vague: some errors, a few people'. Score 3: exact figures: 'vendor invoice Rs 45,000 vs PO Rs 40,000, GST at 18% instead of 12%'. Score 4: 'voucher number, date, threshold — detail is verifiable'.

Step by step

Did you break down exactly what you did — not just the end result?

 **Where it comes from:** Thinking rubric, Specificity — Score 1: one or two steps, no process visible. Score 3: 'analyses the situation into its parts, names exact steps taken, includes amounts, dates, documents'. Score 4: full process plus what happened after — a system created, a habit built.

Goes beyond

Did you add something new — a lesson, a system, an insight beyond the question?

 **Where it comes from:** Thinking rubric, Specificity (Score 4 marker) — 'adds a prevention system, a follow-up action, a process change or a learning not in the original question. Shows that the experience has been fully processed and internalised'.

REASONING

The why

Can we see why you made that choice — not just what you did?

 **Where it comes from:** Thinking rubric, Reasoning — Score 0: 'no reasoning visible, pure description only'. Score 2: 'cause and effect visible, reasoning present but not fully developed'. Score 4: 'generates a new insight, reflects on what they learned and what changed as a result'.

Options weighed

Did you consider more than one approach and explain why you chose this one?

 **Where it comes from:** Thinking rubric, Reasoning — Score 1: 'states what they would do without any consideration of alternatives'. Score 3: 'considers more than one option, explains why they chose their approach over alternatives — thinking is structured, not instinctive'.

Judgment shown

Did you make a deliberate call and own it — not just say what sounded safe?

 **Where it comes from:** Thinking rubric, Reasoning — Score 1: 'knows the right thing to say, does not demonstrate it'. Score 3: 'made a deliberate and informed professional choice, consequence is understood, outcome is owned'. Score 4: 'complete ownership, no deflection, impact named'.



What you learned

Did you say what changed — what you do differently now because of this?

 **Where it comes from:** *Thinking rubric, Reasoning (Score 4 marker) — 'does not just explain what happened — generates a new insight from it. Reflection is present and specific. States what they learned and what they changed. Thinking is not just structured — it is generative'.*

JOB COMPETENCY



Right behaviour

Did you show the behaviour this role needs — not just describe that you have it?

 **Where it comes from:** *Thinking rubric, Job Competency — Score 1: 'understands why the competency matters but cannot demonstrate or construct the actual behaviour'. Score 3: 'made a deliberate and informed professional choice, shows awareness of professional norms and accountability'. Score 4: 'behaviour is demonstrated at the highest level'.*



Impact owned

Did you take ownership of the result — no deflection, no passive language?

 **Where it comes from:** *Thinking rubric, Job Competency — Score 0: passive language: 'it was fixed', 'we handled it'. Score 3: 'outcome is owned, no deflection'. Score 4: 'ownership is complete, impact is quantified or named, something new was built from the experience'.*